American Intelligence

A Briefing for the Republic

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Elizabeth Qiu · 2025–2026
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American Inflection

Setting the stage

You can see the future first in San Francisco.[1] But look closely, and you can see it first anywhere.

I'm from Maryland, right outside the nation's capital. I spent high school working from startups to political campaigns, plugged into what was happening in the Bay Area from 3,000 miles away. Considering my interests, you probably would have guessed that I had frequented the San Francisco Bay Area. The truth is, I did not visit California until a work trip in 2025. But I'd been watching the future arrive from Maryland my whole life.

Growing up near DC meant closely following political news and current events. Every election cycle, you'll hear candidates swear it was the most consequential election in history. How could every one be the most consequential? Maybe they're right—each time period builds on the last, so the present always carries the highest stakes.

At home, I grew up surrounded by people fluent in power—law, diplomacy, business, and consulting—but less so in technology or the arts. The people shaping policy are often not the same people with a deep understanding of the tools. And the people who are building aren't always thinking about broader rules, policy complexities, and societal impact. With a foot in many worlds, I've spent much of my life trying to connect them, following Silicon Valley's ideas, New York's money, and Washington's power up close.

We are at a technological inflection point: another industrial revolution. But before we coordinate or solve what's coming, we have to understand the stakes: what's possible, what's at risk, and where we're heading. That starts with a conversation, not just for us in the thick of it, but also for those outside of the bubble wondering what to make of it all.

In 2025, I took a decade's worth of notes, questions, projects, and observations from Washington to San Francisco. What followed were conversations and explorations across the worlds of technology, policy, and institutions.

The future may be tested in San Francisco first, but it shows up everywhere: in hearing rooms, on trading floors, and at kitchen tables. This essay is an attempt to make sense of some of what I found as we approach what might, this time, actually be the most consequential time period in history.

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1. Leopold Aschenbrenner, *Situational Awareness: The Decade Ahead* (June 2024), Introduction.